

Mosque-Cathedral of Córdoba

A Renaissance cathedral inside an enormous mosque in a unique combination of Moorish and Christian architecture



The Umayyad dynasty, originating in Mecca, established a caliphate in Damascus in the 7th century CE and invaded the Iberian peninsula in 711. The dynasty was deposed in the East in 750 but continued to flourish in Spain. In 929, a new caliphate was founded in Córdoba, elevating the Umayyad capital to one of the greatest cultural centers in Europe.

Work on Córdoba's mosque was begun in 786, on the orders of Abd al-Rahman I, the leader of the Umayyad dynasty. It was built on the site of Córdoba's Roman temple and later Visigoth church, and many of its materials were cannibalized from these older structures.

Columns and arches

The most striking feature of the mosque is the forest of marble columns and arches that extends along its main hall. Originally,

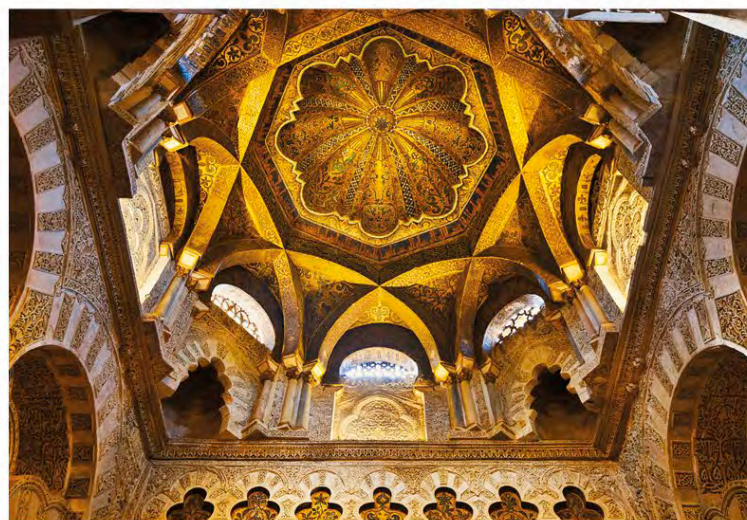
there were more than 1,200 of these, but only around 850 survive. The horseshoe arches, with alternating bands of red brick and white stone, are particularly distinctive. The mosque's most opulent feature is the stunning *mihrab* (prayer niche), which was added by the Umayyad caliph al-Hakam II (r.961–976) in 962.

Part of the mosque was demolished in the 16th century to make way for the cathedral. At the same time, the minaret was transformed into a belfry, the Alminar Tower. The building is now fully protected, having been added to UNESCO's World Heritage Site list in 1984.



◁ DECORATIVE PATTERN

The walls and ceiling of the room-sized *mihrab* in the Córdoba mosque are decorated with plantlike patterns.



◁ PRAYER HALL

The great prayer hall has row upon row of horseshoe arches. The columns are of unequal length, as many were reused from earlier buildings.

△ DOME OVER THE MIHRAB

Above the imposing *mihrab* is a spectacular dome with mosaic decoration in the form of an eight-pointed star.

FLOOR PLAN OF THE BUILDING

The former mosque measures 590 by 425 ft (180 by 130 m). At the entrance is the "Court of the Oranges" leading to a columned prayer hall, which ends with the *mihrab*. Since 1236, the complex has served as a Christian cathedral with the addition of a central high altar and numerous chapels along its sides.

